

It's probably safe to say that our days begin and end with us peering at some digital screen or another. We wake up to alarms on our phone, check our emails on it, order groceries, services and various other items on them, pay for these utilities online, and capture and store pictures and videos on them, more often of a personal nature than not. We've practically given away huge chunks of our lives on the cloud, and it's very rare for anyone to stop and think of the possibility of our data falling into the wrong hands.

But it's happening here and now, in front of our very own eyes. You'd have to be living under a rock if you don't know about the massive data dumps that have been posted on the internet recently. Large amounts of confidential data, not limited to names and physical addresses, but also sensitive information such as credit card details and account passwords have been compromised, and have generally stemmed from a security breach of a large corporation's servers. And considering our increasing reliance on computer systems and "smart" devices, including smartphones, televisions and other electronic devices that are part of the Internet of Things, we've only started providing more ammo to hackers and cyber-terrorists, looking to create havoc and disrupt our routine.

Such incidents only further emphasize the need to safeguard our data and proceed with caution when giving away personal details on the internet. For those who still are unable to fathom the gravity of the situation and the threat these cyber-criminals pose to our life, we'll just take a look at some incidents of mass hacking that have had severe consequences for all parties involved.

LinkedIn

If we look at the LinkedIn hack, back in 2012, passwords for nearly 6.5 million user accounts were stolen by Russian cyber-criminals, and many were unable to log into their accounts following the theft. A LinkedIn hack might not seem like such a big deal for those who don't use the website regularly, but the theft in 2012 turned out to be worse than anyone anticipated. In May 2016, an additional 100 million email addresses and hashed passwords were leaked from the same 2012 breach. And soon after the leak, dozens of celebrity Twitter accounts were hacked, including that of Mark Zuckerberg. All signs pointed to the fact that Zuckerberg used the same LinkedIn password for his Twitter account, which is a pretty common mistake. Another problem that was highlighted after analysing the data dump was the lack of password etiquette, despite people being constantly told to keep different